



sharp, thin, spiky leaves
minimize water loss



SW. North
America

The Mojave Desert

Home of the lowest, hottest point in North America, giant yuccas, and moving stones

North America's smallest, driest desert is sandwiched between the cold Great Basin Desert to the north and the hot Sonoran Desert to the south. Due to its proximity to two contrasting desert areas, experts rarely agree on the Mojave's boundaries, size, or type.

Levels of extremes

Badwater Basin in the Mojave's Death Valley lies 282 ft (86 m) below sea level—the continent's lowest point—yet Telescope Peak in the Panamint Range soars 11,043 ft (3,366 m) above it. North America's highest air temperature of 134°F (57°C) was recorded here, at Furnace Creek in 1913, yet winter temperatures regularly drop below freezing. Winds above 50 mph (80 kph) often buffet the Mojave's western edge but are rare in the east. In the north, low-growing scrubland resembles the Great Basin Desert, but to the south, creosote bush takes hold.

The Joshua tree, the largest North American yucca, is a symbol of the Mojave and is often used by ecologists as an indicator of the desert's southern boundary. Death Valley is also home to "sailing stones"—boulders that appear to move unaided (see panel, left).

branching stem
covered in fire-resistant
fibrous bark



◁ DEVIL'S GOLF COURSE

In Death Valley, growing crystals push against one another, forming an inhospitable, jagged landscape called the Devil's Golf Course.

△ MYSTERIOUS MOVERS

Stones, some as large as 700 lb (320 kg), move across a dry lakebed in Death Valley. They leave behind them trails up to 1,500 ft (460 m) long.